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ENGL 251

22 March 2020

Candy: the Side Character that Embodies Disillusionment and Foreshadows Hopelessness

From my perspective, as one of the most important side characters in John Steinbeck's *Of Mice and Men*, the old disabled handyman, Candy, not only serves as a symbolic figure whose disillusionment is a metaphor that reveals the cruelty of the extreme inequality under capitalism, but also foreshadows George's hopeless destiny after losing his best friend, Lennie.

Among the young and muscular ranch workers, old Candy is probably the most unremarkable one (besides Crooks) as he lost one of his hands because of an accident, and the only work that this unfortunate "swamper" could do is sweeping the bunkhouses. Predictably, if in the future, Candy becomes too old to pick up the broom and "can't swamp out no bunkhouses" (p. 30), the boss will mercilessly put him on the county without any hesitation, and he has no alternative but to accept this miserable destiny. So if we say that Crooks gives Steinbeck an opportunity to discuss social discrimination based on skin color, then Candy is a metaphor of social discrimination based on age and disability. Because of age, Candy's greatest fear is to be used up and thrown out, just as he says, "I won't have no place to go, an' I can't get no more jobs" (p. 30). And because of disability, Candy's greatest dream is to have a small piece of land shared with George and Lennie—living on their own land, he "could cook and tend the chickens and hoe the garden some" (p. 30), and the only thing that may make him worried is to count the number of rabbits and chickens correctly. However, as the fantasy of Candy

disillusioned with the death of Curley's wife, he finally realized that "Then—it's all off?" (p. 47). He will never get "a little win'mill", "a little shack on it", and "a chicken run" (p. 28) that he had once dreamed of. Instead, the only thing left for him is nothing but hopelessness.

Apart from the metaphorical disillusionment of his dream, the significance of Candy also lies in the function of foreshadowing George's desperate future life. In *Of Mice and Men*, there are two couples of intimate friends and companions, one is George and Lennie, and the other is Candy and his loyal dog. The companionship between Candy and his dog parallels the relationship of George and Lennie: for George, Lennie is his spiritual support that makes him weave fascinating fairy tales; for Candy, the dog is his affectionate comrade who distinguishes him from other lonely ranch hands. As Carlson and Slim convinced Candy to abandon his dog because "He's all stiff with rheumatism. He ain't no good to you, Candy. An' he ain't no good to himself." (p. 23), he had to compromise, "for Slim's opinions were law" (p. 23). The old dog didn't do anything wrong, he had to die just because he was aging. Lennie also didn't mean to hurt anybody, he killed Curley's wife just because he couldn't control his giant hands. Both of them were finally shot dead by a bullet from the back of the head, the only difference is that the dog was shot by Carlson, but Lennie was killed by George as Candy told him, "I ought to of shot that dog myself, George. I shouldn't ought to of let no stranger shoot my dog." (p. 31)—because of Candy's suffering, George resolved to take the responsibility for killing Lennie by himself to prevent him from torment at the end of the novel.

Reference

- [1] Steinbeck, John. *Of Mice and Men*. Web. <https://c.zju.edu.cn/webapps/blackboard/execute/content/file?cmd=view&content_id=_133690_1&course_id=_5154_1>. Accessed 20 February 2020.